



Hydra malware targets banks

Hydra banking trojan is back and targets Commerzbank, Germany's second-largest financial institution. <https://dgit.in/oct21-41>



Emergency chrome update

Google released Chrome v94.0.4606.71 to fix two 0-day vulnerabilities. <https://dgit.in/oct21-42>

Google Pixel Buds A-Series

Going handsfree

The competition in the mid-range segment of truly wireless earphones is heating up! In 2021, we've already seen some stellar mid-range TWS under ₹10,000 such as the Oppo Enco X, the OnePlus Buds Pro and a few others. Google has entered the race with its own TWS product under 10K that we're going to be taking a closer look at – the Google Pixel Buds A-Series.

BUILD AND COMFORT

The Google Pixel Buds A-Series are nearly identical to the 2020 Pixel Buds. The Tamagotchi-esque charging case is almost the same size as well but it does not have wireless charging support. The case houses the USB-C port at the bottom, an LED light on the front, and a pairing button at the back. The case is also very compact and slides into pockets easily.

Moving on to the buds, they're compact and lightweight, weighing 5gs each. The buds have a dual matte and glossy texture that looks aesthetically pleasing. The back of the buds houses Google's G logo and it also doubles as the touch-sensitive zone for controls.

The Pixel Buds A-Series provides an excellent fit that is not only secure but also extremely comfortable over hours of listening. You can use these earbuds when you're walking, jogging or exercising since they have a secure fit and IPX4 water resistance as well.

FEATURES

Google has gone down a different route and has chosen not to add Active Noise Cancellation to these buds. Instead, Adaptive Sound is Google's alternative to noise cancellation. Essentially, what this feature does is compensate for external sounds by simply raising the volume of whatever you're listening to automatically. This feature worked well in most instances, but, there were some cases when the volume levels weren't

adjusted to desired levels or at the right moment.

The Google Pixel Buds A-Series come equipped with touch controls for music playback and calls. Now, most TWS earbuds in this price range come with an app that allows users to customise these controls. Sadly, this isn't the case for the A-Series. The Pixel Buds app only gives users the option to turn off touch controls. You can also use the app to switch between Normal and Bass Boost EQ modes, toggle Adaptive Sound, Find your device, and toggle in-ear detection.

One of the most interesting features is handsfree Google Assistant. All you need to do is say "Hey Google" to activate Assistant. We used Assistant much more with these earphones than any other earbuds due to the sheer convenience of handsfree Assistant.

PERFORMANCE

The earbuds feature custom-designed 12mm dynamic drivers and support the SBC and AAC audio codecs. These buds deliver a fairly balanced, close to neutral sound, however, the bass response is somewhat muted on the default EQ setting. The entire bass region of the frequency range is under-

emphasised. This means genres such as rap, hip hop, pop, EDM, and Bollywood will lack thump and punchiness when it comes to bass. However, all this is pretty easily rectified by turning on the Bass Boost EQ preset in the Pixel Buds app... for Android devices only. Yeah, if you do own an iOS device, you're pretty much stuck with what you get since the app is not yet supported on iOS. Moving on the microphone performance, it picks voices up well. Voice sounds pretty natural with very little distortion.

BATTERY LIFE

The Google Pixel Buds A-Series' battery life is nothing to write home about. The wireless playtime on the earbuds is rated at 5 hours and the total battery life along with the charging case is 24 hours. In our tests, the earbuds lasted a little over 4 and a half hours on a single charge. The case provided an additional 3-4 charges, keeping true to the company's rating.

VERDICT

Priced at Rs 9,999, the Google Pixel Buds A-Series is a solid mid-range TWS with good sound and microphone quality. But, other options in the same price range such as the Oppo Enco X and OnePlus Buds Pro look more enticing from a features point of view. Additionally, the Enco X also sounds better than the Pixel Buds A-Series, so it is hard to wholeheartedly recommend the Buds A-Series.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

COLOUR: Clearly White | **HEADPHONE TYPE:** True Wireless | **SWEAT PROOF:** Yes IPX4 | **HEADPHONE DRIVER UNITS:** 12 mm | **BLUETOOTH VERSION:** 5 | **PLAY TIME:** 24 hrs (with charging case), 5 hrs (earbuds only) | **CODECS:** SBC and AAC | **HANDSFREE GOOGLE ASSISTANT:** Yes

CONTACT

GOOGLE | **PHONE:** NA | **EMAIL:** NA | **WEBSITE:** <https://support.google.com/>



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